The Team Health Playbook

How to Diagnose, Fix, and Sustain High-Performing Teams

By Janis Rozenblats

> *"The best time to fix a team problem was three months ago. The second best time is today."*

A Note Before We Start

I've spent twenty years building and leading teams. I built Mailigen from four people crammed into a 12-square-meter office to forty people and an acquisition in 2020. I served as VP Product at Pipedrive — a 700-person company navigating a private equity transition with Vista Equity Partners. Now I'm leading product transformation at a robotics startup, crossing the chasm from scrappy early-stage to disciplined scale.

Along the way, I've made every mistake in this playbook. I've watched teams go silent. I've seen talented people burn out on hamster wheels. I've lost great people because I wasn't paying attention.

This playbook is what I wish someone had handed me at each of those stages. It's not theory. It's the distilled, practical toolkit I use every single week. Every framework has been tested in real companies, with real teams, under real pressure.

Here's my promise: if you spend one hour reading this and one week implementing it, you'll understand your team better than most leaders do after years. And you'll have specific moves to make things better — starting tomorrow morning.

Let's get into it.

PART 1: The 5 Dimensions of Team Health

Why Most Leaders Get Team Health Wrong

Here's how most leaders think about team health: they wait until something breaks. Someone quits. A project fails. Two people stop speaking to each other. Then they react.

That's not leadership. That's firefighting.

The problem isn't that leaders don't care about their teams — most do, deeply. The problem is they don't have a framework for thinking about team health *before* things break. They rely on gut feel. And gut feel is unreliable, because by the time your gut tells you something's wrong, it's been wrong for months.

I learned this the hard way at Mailigen. We were fifteen people and things felt great — until suddenly they didn't. Two engineers quit in the same week. I was blindsided. But when I looked back honestly, the signals had been there for months. I just didn't have a system for seeing them.

That's why I developed the CETAG framework. Five dimensions. Every team problem I've ever encountered traces back to one or more of these five things. Once you see through this lens, you can't unsee it.

The CETAG Framework

C — Clarity E — Energy T — Trust A — Alignment G — Growth

These aren't abstract values to hang on a wall. They're diagnostic lenses. Think of them like vital signs for your team. A doctor doesn't wait for a patient to collapse before checking blood pressure. You shouldn't wait for a resignation letter before checking Clarity.

Let me break each one down.

Dimension 1: Clarity

The question: Does every person on this team know exactly what they should be doing, why it matters, and how success is measured?

Clarity is the most underrated dimension. Leaders think they've been clear because they said something once in an all-hands meeting. But saying something is not the same as being understood. And being understood is not the same as being internalized.

Here's my test: if I walk up to any person on my team and ask "What are the three most important things you're working on this quarter, and why do they matter?" — they should be able to answer without hesitation. If they pause, hedge, or give me a different answer than I would give, we have a Clarity problem.

What Clarity looks like when it's healthy:

- People make decisions autonomously because they understand priorities
- New information gets filtered through shared context — people can self-organize
- Debates happen about *how* to do things, not *what* to do or *why*
- When plans change, people understand the reasoning quickly

What Clarity decay looks like:

- People ask permission for things they should decide themselves
- The same questions come up repeatedly in different meetings

- Work gets done that nobody asked for — "I thought this was the priority"
- People feel busy but can't articulate impact
- There's a gap between what leadership thinks the team is doing and what's actually happening

The Clarity cascade:

Clarity breaks down in layers. At the top, the leader might have a clear vision. But it degrades at every level:

Level	Clarity Question	Common Failure
Mission	Why does this team exist?	Assumed, never stated explicitly
Strategy	What's our approach to winning?	Confused with a list of projects
Priorities	What matters most right now?	Everything is priority 1
Roles	Who owns what?	Overlapping or orphaned responsibilities
Success metrics	How do we know we're winning?	Vanity metrics or no metrics at all
Individual	What should I do today?	No connection between daily work and team goals

Clarity problems often masquerade as other problems. A team that seems to "lack accountability" often actually lacks Clarity. People aren't dodging responsibility — they genuinely don't know what's expected of them.

One thing you can do today: Ask three people on your team, independently, to name the team's top three priorities. If you get three different answers, you've found your first problem.

Dimension 2: Energy

The question: Does this team have the emotional and physical capacity to do great work?

Energy isn't about working hours. I've seen teams work 60-hour weeks with incredible energy, and I've seen teams work 35-hour weeks in a state of exhaustion. Energy is about the ratio of fuel to friction.

Fuel includes: meaningful work, progress, recognition, autonomy, connection to purpose, good relationships.

Friction includes: unnecessary meetings, unclear processes, political maneuvering, context switching, technical debt, bad tools, and — most insidiously — the feeling that your work doesn't matter.

When I was building Mailigen, we had stretches where the team was working incredibly hard but buzzing with energy. Why? Because every feature shipped, every customer won, every bug fixed — it all felt connected to survival and growth. The work was hard but meaningful.

Compare that to what I've seen in larger organizations: people spending 60% of their week in meetings, producing slide decks that no one reads, filling out forms that don't connect to outcomes. That's not work — that's performance art.

What healthy Energy looks like:

- People are genuinely engaged in their work, not just going through the motions
- There's a sustainable pace — intensity when needed, recovery when possible
- Friction gets identified and removed, not accepted as "just how things are"
- People bring discretionary effort — they do more than the minimum because they want to
- After hard pushes, the team recovers and doesn't carry resentment

What Energy decay looks like:

- Increasing cynicism — eye rolls in meetings, sarcastic comments in Slack
- People stop suggesting improvements — "what's the point?"

- Sick days increase, especially on Mondays and Fridays
- Meeting cameras off, mics muted, minimal participation
- The team delivers, but nothing more — no initiative, no creativity, no going the extra mile
- Clock-watching behavior

The Energy equation:

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Team Energy = (Meaning + Progress + Autonomy + Connection) − (Friction + Politics + Ambiguity + Overlo
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Your job as a leader isn't to be a cheerleader. It's to maximize the left side and minimize the right side of this equation. That means two things:

1. **Protect meaning.** Make sure people can see how their work connects to something that matters.
2. **Kill friction.** Ruthlessly eliminate the things that drain energy without creating value.

One thing you can do today: Cancel one recurring meeting that doesn't create obvious value. Just cancel it. See if anyone notices. (They usually don't.)

Dimension 3: Trust

The question: Do people on this team feel safe enough to be honest, take risks, and hold each other accountable?

Trust is the dimension everyone talks about but few understand. When most leaders say "we need more trust," they mean "people should trust me more." But trust on a team is multi-directional:

- **Upward trust:** Do team members trust their leader?
- **Downward trust:** Does the leader trust the team?
- **Lateral trust:** Do team members trust each other?
- **Institutional trust:** Does the team trust the organization?

All four matter. And they're all different.

I've worked with leaders who had great upward trust (their teams loved them) but terrible lateral trust (team members didn't trust each other). That creates a hub-and-spoke dynamic where everything flows through the leader. It doesn't scale.

At Pipedrive, during the PE transition, I watched institutional trust erode overnight. The people were the same. The work was the same. But the moment ownership changed, everyone was asking: "What does this mean for me? Are layoffs coming? Will our culture change?" That kind of trust deficit doesn't respond to pep talks. It responds to transparency, consistency, and time.

The Trust spectrum:

Level	Behavior	What it sounds like
Broken	Self-protection, CYA behavior	"I need that in writing."
Transactional	Follow-through, basic reliability	"They do what they say."
Relational	Vulnerability, honest feedback	"I screwed up. Help me fix it."
Generative	Constructive conflict, creative risk	"This idea is half-baked, but hear me out..."

Most teams operate between Transactional and Relational. Very few reach Generative trust, where people can throw out wild ideas, challenge each other directly, and work through conflict without it becoming personal.

I'm a big believer in Radical Candor — the idea that you can care personally while challenging directly. But Radical Candor only works on a foundation of trust. Without trust, "challenging directly" just feels like an attack.

What healthy Trust looks like:

- People admit mistakes openly, without fear
- Feedback flows in all directions — up, down, and sideways
- Disagreements are visible and productive, not suppressed
- People give each other the benefit of the doubt
- Commitments are taken seriously — when someone says they'll do something, they do it

What Trust decay looks like:

- Meetings after the meeting — the real conversations happen in hallways and DMs
- People agree in meetings but don't follow through
- Feedback only flows downward, never upward
- Blame culture — when something goes wrong, the first question is "whose fault?" not "how do we fix it?"
- Information hoarding — people keep things close to the chest
- Passive-aggressive behavior — silence, sarcasm, malicious compliance

One thing you can do today: In your next 1:1, ask: "What's one thing I could be doing better as your leader?" Then listen. Don't defend. Don't explain. Just listen and say thank you.

Dimension 4: Alignment

The question: Is this team pulling in the same direction, or is everyone optimizing for their own piece of the puzzle?

Alignment is not agreement. I don't need everyone to agree. I need everyone to understand the direction, commit to it, and pull together — even if they personally would have chosen differently.

I borrowed this from the Adizes CAPI framework (Coalescing Authority, Power, and Influence). The idea is that decisions need to bring together the people with formal authority, the people with the power to block or enable execution, and the people with the influence and expertise to make the decision good. When these three don't coalesce, you get misalignment — even if everyone technically "agreed."

The classic example: Leadership decides on a new strategy (authority). The engineering team nods along (apparent agreement). But the tech leads who actually have the power to prioritize work don't believe in it, so they subtly deprioritize it in favor of what they think matters. Six months later, leadership is frustrated that "nothing happened." That's an Alignment failure.

The Alignment matrix:

	Understands the direction	Doesn't understand
Agrees with it	✅ Aligned — execute	⚠️ Lucky alignment — fragile
Disagrees	🔄 Commit & execute (disagree and commit)	❌ Misaligned — danger zone

Your goal is to get everyone into the top row. The top-left quadrant is ideal. The top-right is dangerous because it looks like alignment but breaks the moment direction shifts.

What healthy Alignment looks like:

- People can articulate the team's direction in their own words (not reciting a slide)
- When priorities conflict, people escalate quickly and resolution is fast
- Cross-functional work happens without constant coordination overhead
- "Disagree and commit" is practiced genuinely, not resentfully
- Trade-offs are understood — people know what we're *not* doing and why

What Alignment decay looks like:

- Teams optimize locally at the expense of the whole
- People lobby for their pet projects through back channels
- The roadmap says one thing, but the work says another
- "Alignment meetings" multiply — a sure sign that organic alignment is broken
- People don't know who decided something or why
- You hear "that's not my department" as a way to avoid collaboration

At Pipedrive, the PE transition created an alignment crisis not because people disagreed with the direction, but because nobody was sure *what* the direction was. The old strategy hadn't been invalidated, but the new owners hadn't articulated their vision yet. So everyone filled the vacuum with their own assumptions. That's worse than misalignment — it's phantom alignment, where everyone thinks they're aligned but they're actually heading in different directions.

One thing you can do today: Draw a simple "direction diagram" — three bullet points: where we are, where we're going, and why. Share it with your team and ask: "Does this match your understanding?" The gaps will reveal themselves.

Dimension 5: Growth

The question: Do people on this team believe they're growing — in skills, in scope, in impact?

Growth is the dimension that matters most for retention and least for short-term performance. You can have a high-performing team with great Clarity, Energy, Trust, and Alignment — but if people don't feel like they're growing, they'll leave. Maybe not this quarter. But they'll leave.

The Prosci ADKAR model talks about the stages of change: Awareness, Desire, Knowledge, Ability, Reinforcement. I think about Growth the same way. People need to be *aware* of growth opportunities, *desire* them, acquire the *knowledge* and *ability* to grow, and have that growth *reinforced* through recognition and new challenges.

What healthy Growth looks like:

- People can articulate what they've learned in the last six months
- Stretch assignments are common — people take on things slightly beyond their comfort zone
- Failure in pursuit of growth is treated as learning, not punishment
- The team has a mix of senior and junior people, and mentoring happens naturally
- People see a path from where they are to where they want to be
- Leaders actively talk about career development, not just task completion

What Growth decay looks like:

- "I'm not learning anything new" — the most dangerous sentence a team member can say
- People stop volunteering for new challenges
- Your best performers get recruited away and you can't counter because you haven't invested in their growth
- The team becomes homogeneous — same skills, same perspectives, same comfort zone
- Development conversations feel like check-the-box exercises, not genuine investment
- People do the same work at the same level for years without progression

The Growth conversation framework:

Every quarter, have this conversation with each person on your team:

1. **Where are you now?** What are you great at? What's in your comfort zone?
2. **Where do you want to go?** Not just title — what do you want to be *capable* of?
3. **What's the gap?** What skills, experiences, or exposure do you need?
4. **What's the next step?** One specific thing in the next 90 days that stretches you.

5. **How can I help?** What do you need from me to make this happen?

This conversation takes 30 minutes. Do it quarterly and you'll retain your best people. Skip it and you won't.

One thing you can do today: Ask someone on your team: "What's one skill you'd like to develop this year?" Then find them an opportunity to practice it within the next two weeks.

How the Five Dimensions Interact

These dimensions aren't independent. They form a system:

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        CLARITY
       /       \
   ENERGY ---- TRUST
       \       /
      ALIGNMENT
          |
        GROWTH
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Clarity enables Energy. When people know what to do and why, they waste less energy on ambiguity and politics.

Trust enables Alignment. When people trust each other and the process, they can disagree, commit, and move forward together.

Alignment enables Growth. When the team is pulling together, there's space for people to stretch and take on new challenges without the system breaking.

Growth sustains Energy. When people feel like they're developing, they bring more fuel to the work.

Energy sustains Trust. When people aren't burned out and depleted, they have the capacity for honest conversations and generosity.

This means a problem in one dimension usually cascades. A Clarity problem creates an Energy problem. An Energy problem erodes Trust. Trust erosion breaks Alignment. And without Alignment, Growth stalls.

The diagnostic shortcut: When something feels wrong on your team, don't try to diagnose the symptom. Run through CETAG and ask yourself: which dimension is weakest? Fix that one first. The downstream effects often resolve themselves.

The CETAG Quick Assessment

Rate each dimension 1-5. Be honest, not optimistic.

Dimension	Score (1-5)	Key Question
Clarity	___	Can every person articulate our priorities and their role?
Energy	___	Is the team energized, or just going through the motions?
Trust	___	Do people speak up honestly, even when it's uncomfortable?
Alignment	___	Is everyone pulling in the same direction?
Growth	___	Do people feel like they're developing and advancing?
Total	___ / 25	

Scoring guide:

- **20–25:** Your team is in great shape. Focus on sustaining and fine-tuning.
- **15–19:** Solid foundation with room to improve. Identify the lowest dimension and focus there.
- **10–14:** Significant issues. You probably already know something's off. This playbook will help.
- **Below 10:** Crisis mode. Skip to Part 3 for immediate action plans.

PART 2: Diagnostic Questions & Red Flags

Why Asking the Right Questions Matters More Than Having the Right Answers

Most leaders think their job is to have answers. It's not. Your job is to ask questions that surface truth.

Here's the thing about team problems: the team usually knows about them before you do. The information is there. It's in hallway conversations, in the way someone's body language changes in meetings, in the tasks that keep slipping. But it won't surface voluntarily — not unless you create the conditions for it.

That's what diagnostic questions do. They create a safe, structured way for reality to reach you.

I've spent years refining these questions. Some I learned from mentors. Some I developed through painful experience — asking the wrong question and getting a polished non-answer, then figuring out how to ask the *real* question.

The Rules of Diagnostic Questions

Before I give you the question bank, here are the rules:

1. **Never ask yes/no questions.** "Are you happy?" invites a polished "yes." Instead: "What's the most frustrating part of your week?"
2. **Ask about specifics, not feelings.** "How's morale?" is unanswerable. "When was the last time the team celebrated something?" is concrete.
3. **Ask about behaviors, not intentions.** "Do you trust your teammates?" gets you nothing. "When was the last time someone on the team admitted a mistake openly?" gives you signal.
4. **Use the past tense.** "What did you do when that happened?" is more honest than "What would you do if...?" Past behavior reveals truth; hypotheticals reveal aspirations.
5. **Shut up after asking.** The most important thing you do after asking a diagnostic question is nothing. Silence is uncomfortable. Let it be uncomfortable. The discomfort is where truth lives.

Clarity: Diagnostic Questions

For 1:1 Settings

1. **"What are the three most important things you're working on right now, and why do they matter?"** *What you're listening for:* Can they articulate priorities? Do their priorities match yours? Do they know the "why"?
2. **"If you had to cut your workload by half tomorrow, what would you keep?"** *What you're listening for:* Do they understand relative priority, or is everything "important"?
3. **"When you finish a piece of work, how do you know if it was good enough?"** *What you're listening for:* Are there clear quality standards, or is "done" subjective?
4. **"What's one thing you've spent time on this month that you're not sure actually matters?"** *What you're listening for:* Is there waste? Do they feel safe admitting uncertainty?

5. **"If a new person joined the team tomorrow, what would be the hardest thing to explain to them about how we work?"** *What you're listening for:* Hidden complexity, unwritten rules, missing documentation.
6. **"What decision have you been waiting for someone else to make?"** *What you're listening for:* Decision bottlenecks, unclear authority boundaries.
7. **"Walk me through how you decided what to work on this morning."** *What you're listening for:* Is there a system, or is it reactive firefighting?
8. **"What would need to be true for you to make more decisions without checking with me first?"** *What you're listening for:* Clarity gaps, trust gaps, or both.

For Team Settings

9. **"Let's each write down the team's top three priorities. No talking."** *(Collect and compare.) What you're listening for:* Convergence or divergence in understanding.
10. **"For our current top initiative — who is the single person responsible for its success?"** *What you're listening for:* Hesitation, multiple answers, or blank stares.

Clarity Red Flags 🚩

- People regularly ask "Should I be working on X or Y?" — they shouldn't need to ask
- Two people are working on the same problem without knowing it
- A new hire takes more than two weeks to understand what the team is doing and why
- Your roadmap or plan is more than 10 pages — it's not a plan, it's a novel
- People reference different sources as "the plan" — the wiki, the last all-hands, the Slack message
- When you share priorities, people nod but don't ask questions — they've stopped trying to understand
- Projects complete but nobody can explain the impact they had

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Energy: Diagnostic Questions

For 1:1 Settings

11. **"On a scale of 1 to 10, how would you rate your energy at work right now? What would make it one point higher?"** *What you're listening for:* The number matters less than the "one point higher" — that reveals the friction.
12. **"What's the thing you spend time on that drains you the most?"** *What you're listening for:* Specific sources of friction — meetings, processes, tools, people.
13. **"When was the last time you were genuinely excited about a piece of work?"** *What you're listening for:* How long ago was it? If they struggle to answer, Energy is low.
14. **"If I could remove one thing from your plate entirely, what would make the biggest difference?"** *What you're listening for:* The energy tax — what's costing the most for the least return?
15. **"How much of your week is spent doing work that directly creates value vs. work about work?"** *What you're listening for:* The overhead ratio. In healthy teams, it's 70/30. In unhealthy ones, it's inverted.
16. **"When you leave work on Friday, do you feel accomplished or just relieved it's over?"** *What you're listening for:* The difference between meaningful tiredness and depleting exhaustion.
17. **"Are there recurring frustrations that you've stopped bringing up because nothing changes?"** *What you're listening for:* Learned helplessness — the most dangerous form of low energy.

For Team Settings

18. **"Let's list every recurring meeting we have. For each one: what would happen if we stopped doing it?"** *What you're listening for:* Meetings that exist out of habit, not value.
19. **"What's one process we follow that nobody would miss if it disappeared?"** *What you're listening for:* Bureaucratic drag that the team tolerates but resents.

Energy Red Flags 🚩

- Camera-off culture in remote meetings when cameras used to be on
- Slack response times steadily increasing
- People stop decorating their desks, stop sharing personal stuff in channels
- Lunch breaks get shorter (people eat at desks) or much longer (people avoid coming back)
- Nobody volunteers for new projects — everything has to be assigned
- The quality of work is technically fine but feels mechanical — no spark, no craft
- People use phrases like "it is what it is" or "that's just how things are"
- Your best people start updating their LinkedIn profiles

Trust: Diagnostic Questions

For 1:1 Settings

20. **"When was the last time you disagreed with someone on the team openly? How did it go?"** *What you're listening for:* Do people disagree at all? And when they do, is it productive?
21. **"Is there anything about how the team works that frustrates you but you haven't brought up?"** *What you're listening for:* The unsaid things. This question takes courage to ask and answer.
22. **"If you made a significant mistake this week, what would happen?"** *What you're listening for:* Do they expect support or punishment? This reveals the trust floor.
23. **"Who on the team do you go to when you're stuck? Who do you avoid?"** *What you're listening for:* The informal trust network — it's often different from the org chart.
24. **"What's one thing I've done recently that wasn't helpful?"** *What you're listening for:* Their willingness to give you upward feedback. If they say "nothing," trust is low, not high.
25. **"When decisions are made that affect you, do you feel like your input was genuinely considered?"** *What you're listening for:* The difference between being consulted and being heard.
26. **"Do you feel comfortable sharing bad news with me early, or do you tend to wait until you have a solution?"** *What you're listening for:* If they wait, they don't trust how you'll react to bad news.

For Team Settings

27. **"What's something we as a team are pretending isn't a problem?"** *What you're listening for:* The elephant in the room. This question either breaks things open or gets awkward silence — both are informative.
28. **"On a scale of 1-5, how honest are our retrospectives? What would make them more honest?"** *What you're listening for:* Whether the team's feedback mechanisms actually surface truth.

Trust Red Flags 🚩

- People CC their manager on emails "just to keep them in the loop" — that's CYA behavior

- Meeting notes emphasize who said what, not what was decided — people are building paper trails
- Side conversations increase while public channel activity decreases
- People preface opinions with excessive caveats: "I could be wrong, but..." or "This is probably a stupid question, but..."
- New people are warned about certain individuals or topics — "Don't bring up X with Y"
- Nobody pushes back on the leader's ideas in meetings — then complains about them afterward
- Decisions get relitigated — "I thought we decided this" becomes a recurring phrase
- When something goes wrong, the first question is "who" instead of "what"

Alignment: Diagnostic Questions

For 1:1 Settings

29. **"What do you think the team's biggest bet is right now? Do you think it's the right one?"** *What you're listening for:* Do they know the strategy? Do they believe in it?
30. **"Is there a project or initiative you think we should stop doing? Why?"** *What you're listening for:* Do they have the strategic context to evaluate trade-offs?
31. **"When you see another team making a decision that affects us, do you understand why they made it?"** *What you're listening for:* Cross-team alignment and information flow.
32. **"If the CEO asked you what our team is trying to achieve this quarter, what would you say?"** *What you're listening for:* Can they tell the story simply and accurately?
33. **"What's one trade-off we've made recently that you disagree with?"** *What you're listening for:* Healthy disagreement and whether they understand the trade-off even if they disagree.

For Team Settings

34. **"Let's map what each person thinks our top priority is vs. what they're actually spending their time on."** *What you're listening for:* The gap between stated priority and actual behavior.
35. **"Where do we have dependencies on other teams? Are those working smoothly?"** *What you're listening for:* External alignment failures that create internal frustration.

Alignment Red Flags 🚩

- Different team members give different "elevator pitches" for what the team is doing
- Priorities shift frequently without clear explanation
- "Alignment meetings" appear on the calendar — organic alignment has broken down
- People optimize for their own metrics at the expense of team-wide goals
- Cross-functional collaboration feels like negotiation rather than partnership
- You hear "that's not my problem" or "that's above my pay grade"
- Decisions made in one meeting get revisited in another — nobody feels committed
- Someone says "I disagree and commit" but their body language says "I disagree and will sabotage"

Growth: Diagnostic Questions

For 1:1 Settings

36. **"What's one skill you've developed in the last six months? What helped you develop it?"** *What you're listening for:* Active growth or stagnation?
37. **"Where do you see yourself in two years? And be honest — is this role getting you there?"** *What you're listening for:* Trajectory alignment. If this role isn't on their path, you need to know.
38. **"What's the last thing you failed at? What did you learn?"** *What you're listening for:* Do they take on challenges? Is failure treated as learning?
39. **"Is there someone whose job you'd like to learn more about? Why?"** *What you're listening for:* Curiosity and growth orientation.
40. **"If you could redesign your role, what would you add, remove, or change?"** *What you're listening for:* The gap between what they do and what they want to do.
41. **"Do you feel like you're growing faster, slower, or about the same as six months ago?"** *What you're listening for:* The trajectory, not the absolute level. Slowing growth is a retention risk.
42. **"What's one thing I could do to better support your development?"** *What you're listening for:* Your blind spots as a leader.

For Team Settings

43. **"If we could invest in one team-wide skill or capability, what should it be?"** *What you're listening for:* Shared growth priorities and self-awareness about gaps.
44. **"Who has grown the most in the last quarter? What enabled that growth?"** *What you're listening for:* Whether the team recognizes and celebrates growth. Also identifies your growth-enabling practices.

Growth Red Flags 🚩

- Your best people haven't had a meaningful new challenge in six months
- Development conversations only happen during formal review cycles
- People stop attending optional learning opportunities (talks, workshops, conferences)
- The team has become homogeneous — nobody's bringing new perspectives
- When you ask about career aspirations, people say "I'm fine where I am" without energy or conviction
- Junior people aren't leveling up — same mistakes, same output, same scope
- Nobody on the team has been promoted or moved to a new role in the past year
- People describe their work as "the same thing, different day"

The Red Flag Severity Matrix

Not all red flags are equal. Here's how to triage:

Severity	Description	Timeline	Example
🟢 **Monitor**	Early signal, no immediate impact	Address within 30 days	Camera-off culture emerging
🟡 **Attention**	Pattern forming, starting to affect output	Address within 2 weeks	Best performer updating LinkedIn

Severity	Description	Timeline	Example
🟠 **Urgent**	Active degradation of team function	Address within 1 week	People refusing to collaborate cross-functionally
🔴 **Critical**	Team dysfunction, risk of cascading failure	Address immediately	Key people threatening to quit, open conflicts

How to use this: After reviewing the red flags, list every one you've observed. Assign a severity level. Address the 🔴 and 🟠 items this week. Schedule the 🟡 items. Monitor the 🟢 items.

PART 3: Action Playbooks for the 3 Most Common Problems

How to Use These Playbooks

Each playbook follows the same structure:

- **Diagnosis:** How to confirm this is really the problem
- **Root cause:** Why this typically happens
- **The 30-day fix:** Week-by-week action plan
- **Success metrics:** How you know it's working
- **Maintenance:** How to prevent relapse

These aren't theoretical. I've run each of these plays — some multiple times, across different teams and companies.

Playbook 1: The Silent Team

What It Looks Like

The Silent Team is the team that looks fine on the surface. Deliverables ship. Meetings happen. But nobody speaks up. Nobody challenges ideas. Nobody shares bad news until it's too late.

Meetings feel like presentations, not conversations. The leader talks, others nod. Questions are logistical ("when is the deadline?"), never strategic ("should we be doing this at all?"). When you ask for feedback, you get polished, safe answers.

The Silent Team is dangerous because it *looks* functional. But it's brittle. One surprise — a market shift, a competitor move, a key person leaving — and the whole thing cracks, because there's no honest feedback mechanism to adapt.

How to Confirm the Diagnosis

Check these indicators:

- [ ] In meetings, 80%+ of the talking is done by 2-3 people (usually the most senior)
- [ ] When you ask for opinions, people defer: "I agree with what X said"
- [ ] Retrospectives are polite and generic — "communication could be better"
- [ ] You hear about problems from outside the team (other teams, customers) before hearing from the team itself
- [ ] 1:1 conversations reveal frustrations that never surface in group settings
- [ ] New hires start out vocal but go quiet within 2-3 months

If four or more of these are true, you have a Silent Team.

Root Cause

The Silent Team usually has one of three root causes:

1. **The leader punishes honesty.** Not necessarily intentionally. Maybe they get defensive when challenged. Maybe they react to bad news with visible frustration. The team learned: honesty has a cost.
2. **A past incident created fear.** Someone spoke up and got shut down, publicly criticized, or marginalized. Everyone else took note.
3. **Cultural norm.** In some organizations, silence is just how things work. Hierarchy is strong. The boss decides. Everyone else executes. Nobody has ever modeled a different way.

Honest self-assessment: Before running this playbook, ask yourself: "Is there any chance I'm the reason my team is silent?" If the answer is even "maybe," start with yourself.

The 30-Day Fix

Week 1: Create Safety Through Vulnerability

Monday — The Opening Move

Hold a team meeting. Say something like:

> *"I've been thinking about how we work together, and I realized I haven't made it easy enough for people to share honest opinions. That's on me. I want to fix it. Starting this week, I'm going to ask for your honest input more often, and I want you to know that I genuinely want to hear it — especially when it's uncomfortable."*

Then demonstrate vulnerability:

- Share a mistake you made recently and what you learned
- Admit something you're uncertain about
- Ask for help with something specific

Tuesday through Friday:

- In every 1:1, ask one Trust diagnostic question (from Part 2)
- When someone shares something honest, respond with gratitude, not defense
- If someone pushes back on your idea, say "Tell me more about that" instead of defending

The rule for Week 1: You are not allowed to defend, explain, or justify anything. You can only listen, ask follow-up questions, and say thank you.

Week 2: Introduce Structured Dissent

Monday — Introduce "Pre-mortems"

Before your next decision or initiative, run a pre-mortem:

> *"Let's assume it's three months from now and this initiative has failed completely. What went wrong?"*

This gives people permission to voice concerns disguised as hypothetical future problems. It's psychologically safer than saying "I think this is a bad idea."

Implement "Devil's Advocate" rotation:

- Assign one person in each meeting to argue *against* the proposal
- Rotate the role. This makes dissent structural, not personal.

Anonymous input channel:

- Create a simple way for people to share concerns anonymously (anonymous form, suggestion box)

- This is a temporary crutch, not a permanent solution — but it gets hidden concerns into the open

Throughout Week 2:

- In 1:1s, explicitly ask: "What's one thing you disagree with about how we're working?"
- Share what you're hearing (anonymized) with the team: "Several people mentioned concern about X. Let's talk about it."
- Publicly praise someone who challenged an idea, regardless of whether you agreed with them

Week 3: Build Feedback Habits

Introduce structured feedback in meetings:

At the end of every meeting this week, spend 5 minutes on:

1. **What went well in this discussion?**
2. **What didn't we talk about that we should have?**
3. **Was there a moment someone wanted to say something but didn't?**

Start "Two Stars and a Wish": After any project or milestone, each person shares:

- Two things that went well (stars)
- One thing they wish had been different (wish)

1:1 upgrade:

- Ask: "On a scale of 1-10, how honest are our 1:1s? What would make them more honest?"
- Share your own honest assessment first

The key this week: Make feedback *routine*. It should feel like a normal part of how you work, not a special event.

Week 4: Lock In the New Normal

Monday — Retrospective with teeth:

Run a retrospective focused specifically on communication:

- "In the last month, where did silence cost us?"
- "What did we learn only after it was too late?"
- "Who modeled good honest communication this month?" (public recognition)

Codify the changes:

- Write down the team's communication norms: "We share bad news early," "Disagreement is expected and welcomed," "It's safe to say 'I don't know'"
- Post these where the team sees them daily
- Reference them in meetings: "Remember, we said we'd share bad news early — anyone have bad news?"

Measure progress:

- Re-ask the Trust diagnostic questions from Week 1
- Compare answers. Are people being more open?
- Check meeting participation: Is talking time more evenly distributed?

Success Metrics

Metric	Before	Target (30 days)	Target (90 days)
% of people who speak in meetings	20-30%	50%+	70%+

Metric	Before	Target (30 days)	Target (90 days)
Time to surface bad news	Days/weeks	Same day	Real-time
Number of ideas/concerns raised per week	0-1	3-5	5+
1:1 honesty rating (1-10)	4-5	6-7	8+

Maintenance

- Continue the pre-mortem practice for major decisions
- Keep the feedback ritual at the end of meetings — it takes 5 minutes and prevents regression
- Every quarter, ask: "Are we getting more honest or less honest?" Recalibrate if needed
- New hire onboarding should explicitly cover: "We expect honest communication. Here's what that looks like."

Playbook 2: The Hamster Wheel

What It Looks Like

The Hamster Wheel team is busy. Incredibly busy. Everyone is working hard. Calendars are packed. Slack is buzzing. Tasks are being completed.

But nothing meaningful is changing. The same problems persist quarter after quarter. Customers aren't getting happier. The product isn't getting better in any fundamental way. People are running fast but going nowhere.

The Hamster Wheel feels like progress because of the activity. But activity is not progress. Progress is measured by outcomes, not outputs.

I've been on this wheel myself. At Mailigen, around the 25-person mark, we were shipping features constantly. Every sprint delivered something. But when I looked at our key metrics — customer retention, revenue per account, NPS — they were flat. We were building, but we weren't improving. It took a painful honest conversation with my co-founder to realize: we had confused shipping with winning.

How to Confirm the Diagnosis

Check these indicators:

- [ ] The team is consistently busy, but key metrics aren't improving
- [ ] Sprint velocity is high, but customer/business outcomes are flat or declining
- [ ] People can tell you *what* they're doing but not *why it matters*
- [ ] There's no time for reflection, learning, or improvement — always onto the next thing
- [ ] Technical debt, process debt, and organizational debt keep growing
- [ ] When you ask "what did we accomplish this quarter?" you get a list of activities, not outcomes
- [ ] The team feels tired but can't point to meaningful progress
- [ ] "We don't have time for that" is the response to any improvement suggestion

If four or more are true, you're on the Hamster Wheel.

Root Cause

The Hamster Wheel usually has one of three root causes:

1. **No clear prioritization framework.** Everything is "important." Without a way to say no, every request becomes work.

2. **Output culture instead of outcome culture.** The team is rewarded for shipping, not for impact. So they ship. A lot. Without checking whether it matters.
3. **Avoidance through busyness.** This is the subtle one. Sometimes teams stay busy to avoid confronting hard strategic questions. If you're always heads-down on the next task, you never have to ask: "Are we even working on the right things?"

The 30-Day Fix

Week 1: Stop the Wheel (Temporarily)

Monday — The Audit

Block 2 hours. Cancel something if you have to. Do this exercise:

The Activity Impact Matrix:

List every significant activity your team spends time on. For each one, rate:

- **Effort:** How much time/energy does this consume? (High/Medium/Low)
- **Impact:** How much does this contribute to the team's most important goal? (High/Medium/Low)

Activity	Effort	Impact	Verdict
(list)	H/M/L	H/M/L	Keep / Reduce / Stop

Anything that's High Effort + Low Impact is a candidate for immediate elimination.

Share this with the team. Ask for their input. They probably see waste you don't.

Tuesday-Wednesday — Define "Winning"

If your team can't answer "What does winning look like?" then nothing else matters. Define 2-3 outcome metrics. Not output metrics. Not "features shipped" or "tickets closed." Outcome metrics: customer retention, revenue, satisfaction, speed-to-value — whatever matters for your business.

Write them on the wall (physical or virtual). Every decision should reference them.

Thursday-Friday — The Stop-Doing List

This is harder than the to-do list. Identify 3-5 things the team will *stop* doing. Announce them. Be specific:

- "We're canceling the weekly status report — if you need to know something, ask."
- "We're pausing Feature X until we see whether Feature Y moves the metrics."
- "We're reducing our recurring meeting load by 30% this month."

Expect resistance. People on the Hamster Wheel are addicted to motion. Stopping feels dangerous. Reassure them: we're not slowing down, we're redirecting.

Week 2: Redirect Toward Outcomes

Monday — Reframe the sprint/cycle

Instead of planning work as tasks, plan work as bets:

> *"This week, we're betting that if we do X, it will improve Y by Z."*

This forces the team to articulate the connection between work and outcome. If they can't, the work probably shouldn't happen.

Introduce outcome reviews:

At the end of each week, don't ask "What did we ship?" Ask: "What did we learn? Did our bets pay off? What should we bet on next?"

Time audit:

Ask each person to track how they spend their time for one week. Categories:

- Direct value creation (building, designing, solving customer problems)
- Coordination (meetings, emails, Slack about work)
- Administrative (reports, processes, tools)
- Reactive (interruptions, firefighting)

The results will be eye-opening. Most teams discover they spend 30-40% of their time on Coordination and Admin.

Week 3: Protect Focus

Implement "Maker's Schedules":

Block 4-hour uninterrupted focus blocks for individual contributors. No meetings. No Slack. Deep work time. This alone can increase meaningful output by 30-50%.

Meeting diet:

- Every recurring meeting must justify its existence. Apply this test: "What decision does this meeting enable that we can't make otherwise?"
- Reduce meeting length: 60 min → 45 min. 30 min → 20 min. Parkinson's Law — work fills the time available.
- Introduce "no meeting days" — at least one per week.

Reduce Work in Progress (WIP):

The Hamster Wheel runs partly because there are too many things in flight. Limit WIP:

- Each person: no more than 2-3 active work items
- The team: no more than N parallel initiatives (where N = team size / 3, roughly)
- When something new comes in, something else must pause or stop

Week 4: Build the Outcome Rhythm

Monday — Outcome-based planning:

Start the week with: "What outcomes are we driving toward this week? What's the minimum work needed to move toward those outcomes?"

Friday — Outcome review:

End the week with: "Did we move the needle on our outcome metrics? What did we learn? What will we do differently next week?"

Monthly outcome retrospective:

- Plot your outcome metrics over the last month
- Are they trending in the right direction?
- If not, the work you're doing isn't working — change the work, not the effort level

Codify the new operating model:

- "We measure outcomes, not output."
- "Every initiative must connect to a team-level outcome."
- "It's better to do three things well than seven things poorly."
- "Saying no is a leadership responsibility, not a failure."

Success Metrics

Metric	Before	Target (30 days)	Target (90 days)
Hours/week in meetings per person	15-20+	10-12	8-10
Active projects in flight	8-12	4-6	3-5
% of work connected to outcome metrics	30-40%	60%+	80%+
Key outcome metrics	Flat	Starting to move	Clear trend
Team energy (self-reported 1-10)	4-5	6-7	7-8

Maintenance

- Outcome reviews every week — non-negotiable
- Monthly WIP audit — are things creeping back up?
- Quarterly "Stop Doing" exercise — entropy always adds work, you must actively remove it
- Protect focus time ruthlessly — it's the first thing that erodes under pressure

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Playbook 3: The Revolving Door

What It Looks Like

The Revolving Door team can't keep people. You're always hiring, always onboarding, always losing institutional knowledge. Every departure means months of ramp-up time for the replacement. Projects stall during transitions. The remaining team members are stretched thin, covering for vacant roles, which burns them out, which makes *them* more likely to leave. It's a vicious cycle.

I've seen this pattern from both sides. At Mailigen, we had periods of painful attrition — losing people we couldn't afford to lose. At Pipedrive during the PE transition, I watched excellent people leave because the psychological contract had changed. They didn't sign up for PE — they signed up for a certain kind of company.

The worst part of the Revolving Door isn't the direct cost (though that's significant — replacing a team member costs 50-200% of their annual salary). The worst part is the damage to the remaining team's morale and trust. Every departure says: "This place isn't worth staying at."

How to Confirm the Diagnosis

Check these indicators:

- [ ] Annual attrition exceeds 20% (or is significantly higher than industry average)
- [ ] You've lost 2+ people from the same team in the last 6 months
- [ ] Exit interviews reveal similar themes (lack of growth, poor management, misalignment)
- [ ] Your best performers are leaving, not your weakest (that's the most dangerous sign)
- [ ] Time-to-hire is increasing because your employer brand is suffering
- [ ] The team spends significant time onboarding new people at the expense of actual work
- [ ] People leave within the first year — your retention problem starts at onboarding, not later
- [ ] Remaining team members express resignation: "People just leave here"

If four or more are true, you have a Revolving Door.

Root Cause

The Revolving Door usually has one of three root causes:

1. **Growth stagnation.** People don't see a future. The role is the same as it was a year ago, and it'll be the same next year. Talented people outgrow their roles faster than the organization creates new ones.
2. **Management failure.** People don't leave companies, they leave managers. If the Revolving Door is localized to one team or under one leader, the root cause is leadership, not the organization.
3. **Broken promises.** The company sold something during recruiting that doesn't match reality. Culture, flexibility, challenge, impact — if the reality doesn't match the pitch, people feel betrayed and leave.

The hidden cause: Sometimes the Revolving Door is actually rational attrition. If you're hiring the wrong people, or if the role genuinely doesn't fit the market, no amount of culture or management will fix it. Make sure your hiring is right before blaming retention.

The 30-Day Fix

Week 1: Stop the Bleeding

Monday — The Retention Conversation

You can't fix what you don't understand. This week, have an honest conversation with every person on the team. Not a "stay interview" in the HR sense — an actual human conversation.

The question: **"If you were to leave in the next six months, what would be the reason?"**

Don't flinch. Don't defend. Listen. Take notes.

Common answers and what they mean:

Answer	Translation	Dimension
"Better opportunities elsewhere"	"I'm not growing here"	Growth
"I don't feel valued"	"My contributions aren't recognized"	Trust / Energy
"The direction keeps changing"	"I don't understand where we're going"	Clarity / Alignment
"I'm burned out"	"The demands exceed my capacity"	Energy
"I don't trust leadership"	"Decisions are opaque and I feel disposable"	Trust
"I want more money"	Often actually "I want to feel valued" — but sometimes genuinely about compensation	All

Triage the responses. Identify the top 2-3 themes. These become your focus for the next three weeks.

Immediate action — fix the obvious:

- If someone is clearly on the verge of leaving, have the hard conversation now. Don't wait.
- If there's a simple fix (a tool, a process, a specific frustration), fix it this week. Quick wins build credibility.

Week 2: Address the Top Retention Driver

Based on your Week 1 conversations, the top retention risk usually falls into one of these categories. Follow the relevant action plan:

If Growth is the issue:

- Map each person's growth trajectory: current role → next step → timeline
- Identify one stretch opportunity for each person in the next 30 days

- Pair people with mentors (internal or external)
- Create a "growth budget" — time and resources explicitly dedicated to learning
- Have the career conversation from Part 1 (the five Growth questions) with every person this week

If Energy is the issue:

- Run the Hamster Wheel playbook in parallel — overwork and burnout are retention killers
- Identify and remove the top 3 energy drains immediately
- Give people back control over their schedule — autonomy is a key energy driver
- Consider workload redistribution — is the load equitable or are some people carrying too much?
- Plan recovery: if the team has been sprinting, schedule downtime deliberately

If Trust/Alignment is the issue:

- Increase transparency radically — share context, reasoning, and information you might normally keep at leadership level
- Address the specific trust-breaking incidents that came up in conversations
- If the issue is with a specific manager, address it directly — coaching, support, or if necessary, change
- Re-articulate the team's direction and invite genuine input — not after-the-fact buy-in, but actual shaping

Week 3: Build Retention Infrastructure

The "Stay Factors" exercise:

With the team, identify the specific reasons people stay. Not generic things — specific, concrete factors:

Stay Factor	Current Score (1-5)	One Thing We Can Do to Improve
Growth opportunities	___	___
Team relationships	___	___
Meaningful work	___	___
Manager quality	___	___
Compensation/recognition	___	___
Work-life balance	___	___
Company direction	___	___

Focus improvement efforts on the factors that score lowest.

Fix onboarding:

If people leave within the first year, your onboarding is broken. Create a 90-day onboarding experience:

- **Day 1-5:** Logistics + relationships (meet the team, understand the culture)
- **Week 2-4:** Learning (understand the product, the customer, the codebase, the processes)
- **Month 2:** Contributing (first meaningful deliverable, with support)
- **Month 3:** Owning (first piece of work they own end-to-end)

Assign every new hire a "buddy" — not their manager, but a peer who can answer the questions people are embarrassed to ask their boss.

Build early warning systems:

Don't wait for the resignation letter. Monitor:

- Changes in engagement: participation in meetings, social events, optional activities
- Changes in communication patterns: less Slack activity, shorter messages, delayed responses

- Changes in work patterns: lower quality, less initiative, more clock-watching
- Direct signals: updating LinkedIn, talking about "hypothetical" opportunities, asking about equity vesting schedules

Week 4: Lock In and Measure

Implement monthly 1:1 check-ins focused on retention:

Add these questions to your regular 1:1 rotation:

- "On a scale of 1-10, how likely are you to be here in a year?"
- "What would make that number higher?"
- "What's the best thing about working here? What's the worst?"

Track retention metrics:

- Monthly attrition rate (rolling 12 months)
- Time-to-productivity for new hires
- Internal mobility rate (people moving to new roles vs. leaving)
- Engagement scores by dimension (use the Weekly Pulse from Part 4)

Create a retention dashboard:

You track revenue, customer churn, and pipeline. Track people metrics with the same rigor.

Celebrate tenure and loyalty:

Recognize people who stay and grow. Not with plaques — with opportunities, visibility, and genuine appreciation.

Success Metrics

Metric	Before	Target (30 days)	Target (90 days)
Voluntary attrition (annualized)	20%+	—	15% or below
Regrettable departures per quarter	2+	0-1	0
New hire 90-day retention	<80%	—	90%+
"Likely to stay 1 year" (avg 1-10)	5-6	7	8+
Time for departing employee to flag intent	At resignation	1-2 months before	Ongoing conversation

Maintenance

- Monthly "pulse check" on retention factors
- Quarterly growth trajectory conversations with every person
- Continuous improvement of onboarding — ask every new hire at 90 days: "What would have helped you ramp faster?"
- When someone does leave, do a genuine exit conversation (not an HR checkbox) and extract learning
- Track and share "boomerang" rate — people who leave and come back. If it's high, you're doing something right

PART 4: The Weekly Pulse Framework

Why You Don't Need Expensive Engagement Tools

I've used Gallup. I've used Culture Amp. I've used custom-built engagement surveys. Here's what I learned: annual or even quarterly surveys are too slow, too abstract, and too disconnected from the rhythms of actual work.

By the time you get the results, analyze them, create action plans, and start implementing — six months have passed. The problems have either resolved themselves or metastasized into something the survey can't help with.

What you need is a fast, lightweight, continuous signal. Something that takes two minutes per person per week and tells you, in near-real-time, how your team is doing across the five CETAG dimensions.

That's the Weekly Pulse.

The 5 Pulse Questions

Every Friday (or the last day of your work week), each person answers five questions. Rating: 1-5. No explanations required (though they can add comments if they want).

#	Question	Dimension	What it measures
1	"I knew exactly what I needed to focus on this week."	Clarity	Priority clarity and role clarity
2	"I had the energy and motivation to do my best work."	Energy	Fuel vs. friction ratio
3	"I felt comfortable being honest with my team this week."	Trust	Psychological safety
4	"The work I did this week connected to something that matters."	Alignment	Connection between work and purpose
5	"I learned or grew in some way this week."	Growth	Development and challenge

That's it. Five questions. Two minutes.

How to Implement the Weekly Pulse

Setup (30 minutes, one time)

Option 1: Low-tech

- Create a shared spreadsheet
- One column per week, one row per question, one tab per person
- People fill it in every Friday before leaving

Option 2: Medium-tech

- Create a recurring form (Google Forms, Typeform, whatever you use)
- Auto-send every Friday at 3 PM
- Results aggregate into a dashboard

Option 3: Slack/Teams

- Set up a weekly bot prompt: "It's Pulse time! Rate 1-5 on each dimension."
- Responses go to a private channel or spreadsheet

Keep it anonymous or named — your choice. I prefer named because it allows for follow-up conversations, but anonymous works if trust is still building.

The Monday Morning Ritual (15 minutes)

Every Monday morning, before anything else, review the Pulse data from Friday.

Step 1: Calculate averages (2 minutes)

Dimension	This Week	Last Week	Trend
Clarity	___	___	↑ ↓ →
Energy	___	___	↑ ↓ →
Trust	___	___	↑ ↓ →
Alignment	___	___	↑ ↓ →
Growth	___	___	↑ ↓ →

Step 2: Identify signals (3 minutes)

- Any dimension below 3.0? → Immediate attention needed
- Any dimension dropped by 0.5+ from last week? → Something changed. Find out what.
- Any individual consistently scoring low? → Private conversation this week.
- Any dimension trending down for 3+ weeks? → Systemic issue. Deploy relevant playbook.

Step 3: Decide one action (5 minutes)

Based on the data, pick ONE thing you'll do this week to address the weakest signal. Not three things. One thing.

Examples:

- Clarity dropped → Start the week by re-stating priorities in the team channel
- Energy dropped → Cancel one meeting and protect a focus block
- Trust dropped → Ask a vulnerability question in your next 1:1
- Alignment dropped → Share context on a recent decision the team wasn't part of
- Growth dropped → Assign a stretch task to someone who's been doing routine work

Step 4: Share with the team (5 minutes)

This is optional but powerful. Share the aggregate trends (not individual scores) with the team:

> *"Our Pulse this week: Clarity 4.1, Energy 3.2, Trust 3.8, Alignment 4.0, Growth 3.5. Energy dipped — I'm canceling Thursday's status meeting to give everyone a focus block. If energy is low for you specifically, let's talk in our 1:1."*

This does two things: it shows you're paying attention, and it normalizes the conversation about team health.

Trend Tracking

The real power of the Weekly Pulse isn't any single week's data — it's the trends over time.

The 4-Week Trend Chart

After four weeks, you'll have enough data to see patterns. Create a simple line chart:

```
 5.0 |
4.5 |        C——C
4.0 |  C——C          A——A——A——A
3.5 |  A              T——T
3.0 |  T——T——T                G——G
2.5 |  E   G   G——G   E——E
2.0 |      E
    |_____________________________
      W1    W2   W3    W4
```

Patterns to watch for:

- **Synchronized drops:** All dimensions drop together → External event (reorg, layoffs, market shock)
- **Cascading drops:** One dimension drops, others follow weeks later → Find the lead indicator
- **Divergence:** One dimension rising while another falls → Trade-off being made (e.g., Clarity up but Energy down = driving too hard on focus at the expense of wellbeing)
- **Flat lines:** No movement in any direction → Stagnation. Might be fine (stability) or might mean people have stopped caring about the survey

The 12-Week Review

Every quarter, zoom out and review the full 12-week trend:

1. What was our strongest dimension? Why?
2. What was our weakest dimension? What did we do about it?
3. Were there any "crisis weeks" where multiple dimensions dropped? What caused them?
4. What one intervention had the biggest positive impact?
5. What should we focus on improving next quarter?

Common Pitfalls

Pitfall 1: Over-reacting to single-week fluctuations. One person had a bad week and scored everything low. That doesn't mean your team is broken. Look at trends, not snapshots.

Pitfall 2: Turning the Pulse into an interrogation. If someone scores low, don't ambush them: "I saw you scored Energy a 2 — what's wrong?" Instead, in your regular 1:1, casually explore: "How was your week? Anything particularly draining?"

Pitfall 3: Collecting data without acting on it. If you ask people to fill out the Pulse every week but never do anything with the data, they'll stop filling it out. Worse, they'll learn that feedback is performative. Act on the data or stop collecting it.

Pitfall 4: Making it mandatory and mechanical. The Pulse should feel like a quick check-in, not a compliance exercise. Keep it voluntary but encouraged. If participation drops, that's itself a signal.

Pitfall 5: Fixating on averages. An average of 3.5 could mean everyone's at 3.5 (uniformly okay) or it could mean half the team is at 5 and half is at 2 (polarized). Look at the distribution, not just the average.

PART 5: Real Stories from the Trenches

Why I'm Sharing These

I debated whether to include this section. These stories involve real mistakes — my mistakes. It's uncomfortable to put them in writing.

But I included them because I know what it's like to read leadership advice that's all theory and no scars. It doesn't land. The frameworks only make sense when you see them in context — when you see how they break in real life and how they get rebuilt.

So here are three stories from three very different stages of team building. I've changed some details to protect individuals, but the dynamics and lessons are real.

Story 1: What Broke at Mailigen at 15 People vs. 30

The 15-Person Crack

Mailigen started in a 12-square-meter office. Four of us. Every conversation was a team meeting. Every decision was made by everyone, because everyone was in the room.

We grew to fifteen people and for a while, it felt like a bigger version of the same thing. We still ate lunch together. We still knew everything about each other's work. When someone was struggling, we could see it.

Then one Monday morning, I realized I had no idea what one of our developers had been working on the previous week. Not vaguely — completely. I couldn't even guess.

That was the Clarity crack.

At four people, Clarity is automatic — you can't avoid knowing what everyone is doing. At fifteen, you have to be intentional about it. I wasn't.

What followed was predictable in hindsight. Without Clarity, people started making assumptions. Two developers spent a week building features that overlapped. A marketing campaign went out referencing a feature that wasn't ready. A customer got a promise from sales that engineering didn't know about.

I tried to fix it by adding more communication: daily standups, weekly all-hands, status reports. This helped with Clarity but killed Energy. We went from "nobody knows what's happening" to "everybody's in meetings all day talking about what's happening instead of making it happen."

The fix wasn't more communication — it was *better* communication. I introduced three things:

1. **A single source of truth** — one document that listed every active project, its owner, its status, and its priority. Updated weekly. No other status reporting required.
2. **Owner accountability** — every project had one owner (not a team, not a committee — one person). That person was responsible for keeping the source of truth updated and for raising blockers.
3. **Exception-based communication** — instead of everyone reporting everything, people only communicated when something deviated from the plan. No news was good news.

This reduced meeting time by 40% while actually improving Clarity. The lesson: at 15 people, you need systems for things that used to be automatic. But the systems should be lightweight — just enough structure to replace what proximity used to provide.

The 30-Person Fracture

We grew to thirty people and hit a completely different problem: Trust.

At fifteen, trust was personal. Everyone knew each other. Relationships were strong. Feedback was direct because we were friends as well as colleagues.

At thirty, we had people who had never worked together directly. Sub-teams formed. And with sub-teams came sub-cultures. The engineering team had one way of working. The marketing team had another. Sales had their own rhythm.

The fracture showed up in a specific way: the "meeting after the meeting." People would agree on something in the all-hands, then immediately walk to a colleague's desk and say "That's never going to work." The public conversation and the real conversation diverged.

I noticed it because a designer came to me privately and said: "I don't know what we're actually doing. Everyone says different things depending on who's in the room."

This was a Trust problem manifesting as a Clarity problem. People didn't trust the group enough to be honest in the group, so they were honest only in private — which meant different people got different versions of the truth.

My first instinct was wrong. I tried to fix it with process: better meeting notes, decision logs, written commitments. This was treating the symptom, not the disease.

The real fix was harder. I had to model the behavior I wanted:

- I started being more transparent about my own doubts and uncertainties in group settings
- When I heard about a "meeting after the meeting," I brought the concern into the open: "I heard there are questions about X. Let's discuss it now."
- I publicly changed my mind when someone made a good argument — showing that changing your position is strength, not weakness
- I created smaller forums (groups of 5-6) where honest conversation was easier, then brought insights back to the whole team

It took three months, not three weeks. Trust at scale is slow to build and fast to break. But by the time we hit forty people, we had a culture where most conflicts surfaced in the open — not all of them, because that's unrealistic, but enough to make decisions that people genuinely committed to.

The lesson: Every growth stage breaks something that used to work automatically. At 5 people, everything is automatic. At 15, Clarity breaks first. At 30, Trust breaks. At 50+, Alignment breaks. The leader's job is to anticipate these breaks and build systems before the cracks become chasms.

Story 2: How Alignment Collapsed During the Pipedrive PE Transition

I joined Pipedrive as VP Product when it was a 700-person company with strong culture, passionate people, and a clear sense of identity. Then Vista Equity Partners acquired a majority stake.

Let me be clear: PE transitions aren't inherently bad. They bring capital, operational rigor, and growth opportunity. But they fundamentally change the psychological contract between the company and its people.

Before the acquisition, Pipedrive's alignment was values-based. People aligned around a shared sense of mission: build a CRM that salespeople actually love. Decisions were made through principles and culture. It was messy sometimes, but it worked because everyone was pulling from the same set of values.

After the announcement, alignment shattered — not because people disagreed with the direction, but because nobody knew what the direction was anymore.

Here's what I observed, using the CETAG framework:

Clarity went to zero overnight. The strategy hadn't changed on paper, but nobody believed the paper anymore. "Will our roadmap change? Will our priorities shift? Are we going to become a different kind of company?" These questions were unanswerable in the short term, which created a vacuum.

Energy cratered. Not because people were working more — they were working less effectively. Worry consumes energy. I watched highly productive people spend hours in anxious conversations instead of doing their best work.

Trust eroded. Institutional trust — trust in the organization — took the biggest hit. "Why didn't we know about this earlier? What else is leadership not telling us?" Even leaders who had nothing to do with the acquisition were treated with suspicion, because they represented the institution.

Alignment fragmented. Without clear direction, people filled the vacuum with their own priorities. Some doubled down on what they'd been doing, hoping to prove their value. Others went into self-preservation mode, optimizing for visibility rather than impact. A few started interviewing elsewhere.

Growth stalled. Nobody was thinking about development. Survival felt more pressing than learning.

What I Did (and What I'd Do Differently)

What I did:

1. **Extreme transparency within my control.** I couldn't share what I didn't know, but I could share *that* I didn't know, and what I was doing to find out. I held weekly "ask me anything" sessions with my team.
2. **Steady the ship on priorities.** I made a deliberate choice: until the new direction becomes clear, we continue executing on our current plan. No strategic pivots based on speculation.
3. **Individual conversations.** I spent more time in 1:1s than in any other period of my career. Not about work — about how people were feeling, what they were worried about, what they needed.
4. **Protected the team's autonomy.** When top-down changes came, I absorbed as much disruption as I could at my level, shielding the team from unnecessary turbulence.

What I'd do differently:

1. **Name the dynamic earlier.** I waited too long to explicitly say: "We're in a period of uncertainty. That's uncomfortable. Here's how we're going to navigate it." Naming the elephant removes some of its power.
2. **Create transition milestones.** Instead of vague "we'll figure it out," I should have said: "In the next 30 days, we'll know X. In 60 days, we'll know Y. In 90 days, we'll have a clear plan." Even if the milestones shifted, having them would have reduced anxiety.
3. **Address retention proactively.** I lost good people who might have stayed if I'd had the retention conversation from Playbook 3 earlier. I was so focused on steadying the work that I underestimated how much people needed to feel individually valued and secure.

The lesson: During major transitions, the CETAG dimensions don't degrade linearly — they collapse simultaneously. You can't fix all five at once. My advice: stabilize Trust and Clarity first. Trust because people need to believe their leaders are being straight with them. Clarity because people need *something* concrete to hold onto, even if it's "here's what we know and here's what we don't."

Alignment, Energy, and Growth can be rebuilt once Trust and Clarity are restored. Without those two, nothing else takes hold.

Story 3: Leading Transformation at a Robotics Startup — Crossing the Chasm

After Pipedrive, I joined a robotics startup as the executive product leader. The company was at an inflection point: past the early scrappy stage but not yet operating like a scaled organization. My job was to lead that transformation.

This was the hardest team health challenge I've faced, and it's ongoing. Here's why: the team that built the company to this point was optimized for one set of conditions (speed, scrappiness, heroic individual effort), and the team needed to succeed going forward required a completely different operating model (process, coordination, systematic execution).

The fundamental tension: the people who got you here may not be the people who get you there — but they *deserve* to be, if they're willing to grow. That's the tightrope.

What I Found

Clarity was tribal knowledge. Nothing was written down because it didn't need to be — when you're twenty people, everyone knows everything. But as the team grew, new people couldn't access this knowledge. They were dependent on the original team members, who were too busy to teach. This created a two-tier system: insiders who knew how things worked and outsiders who were guessing.

Energy was feast-or-famine. The team operated in crisis mode. A customer issue? Drop everything and fix it. A demo next week? Sprint until it's done. This worked in the early days when every fire was existential. But now it was unsustainable. People were burned out but couldn't imagine another way of working. "That's just how startups work" was the mantra.

Trust was personal, not institutional. People trusted the founder. They trusted their close colleagues. But they didn't trust *the system* because there was no system. Decisions were made based on who had the founder's ear, not based on a transparent process.

Alignment was assumed, not built. Everyone thought they were aligned because they all believed in the mission. But mission alignment and execution alignment are different things. Everyone agreed on *where* the company should go. Nobody agreed on *how* to get there.

Growth was accidental. People had grown enormously — but through baptism by fire, not intentional development. The skills they'd built were real but narrow. And some people had been in the same role for so long that they'd stopped growing entirely without realizing it.

The Transformation Approach

I used the CAPI framework from Adizes: Coalescing Authority, Power, and Influence. Any successful change requires bringing together:

- **Authority:** The formal right to make decisions
- **Power:** The ability to implement or block implementation
- **Influence:** The expertise and credibility to make decisions good

In a startup, these three are often concentrated in the founder. Scaling means distributing them — which means the founder has to let go, and the team has to step up.

Phase 1: Make the implicit explicit (Month 1-2)

I documented everything. Not because I love documentation, but because you can't improve what you can't see. We mapped:

- Every product in the portfolio and its maturity level
- Every team and its responsibilities
- Every process (or lack thereof) for making decisions
- Every customer commitment and its status

This was uncomfortable. Making things explicit means you can no longer hide behind ambiguity. "We all know what we're doing" stops being a valid response when the document shows that people have different understandings.

Phase 2: Introduce process without killing speed (Month 2-4)

This is the classic startup-to-scale tension. Process feels like bureaucracy to people who've operated without it. The key: introduce the *minimum viable process* — enough structure to coordinate, not so much

that it strangles.

I applied the ADKAR change model:

- **Awareness:** Help the team understand *why* process is needed (not "because I said so" but "because we lost a customer last month due to miscommunication that process would have prevented")
- **Desire:** Connect process to outcomes they care about (less firefighting, fewer late nights, more predictable delivery)
- **Knowledge:** Teach the specific processes we'd implement
- **Ability:** Practice and iterate — the first version of any process is wrong; refine it
- **Reinforcement:** Celebrate when process prevents a problem that would have been a fire drill

Phase 3: Build new muscles (Month 4+)

The team needed to develop new capabilities: cross-functional planning, stakeholder management, data-driven decision making, systematic prioritization. These are skills that weren't needed when the company was fifteen people, but are essential at fifty-plus.

This is where the Growth dimension becomes critical. People who grew up in scrappy mode need to see that learning structured approaches isn't a betrayal of startup values — it's the evolution of them. You're not becoming corporate. You're becoming capable of operating at the scale your ambition requires.

The Ongoing Lesson

The transformation is still in progress, and I expect it will be for another year at least. But here's what I've learned:

Pace matters more than perfection. Move too fast with changes and you break trust. Move too slow and you lose credibility. The right pace is fast enough to show progress, slow enough to bring people along.

Respect the past while building the future. The people who built this company in scrappy mode did something incredible. Transformation isn't a verdict that they did it wrong. It's a recognition that what got us here won't get us there — and that's not a criticism, it's a compliment. They succeeded so well that the company outgrew its original operating model.

Some tension is permanent. A robotics startup that's scaling will always have tension between engineering craft and business deadlines, between innovation and process, between speed and quality. The goal isn't to eliminate tension — it's to make it productive.

Team health is the foundation, not the roof. You can't transform an organization on a foundation of broken team health. Fix the CETAG dimensions first, then drive change. Trying to transform a team that doesn't have Clarity, Energy, Trust, Alignment, or Growth is like renovating a house with a cracked foundation.

PART 6: The Quick Start Guide

Your First 5 Days with This Playbook

You've read the framework, the diagnostic questions, the playbooks, and the stories. Now it's time to act. Here's exactly what to do, day by day, starting tomorrow.

Day 1 (Monday): Assess

Time required: 45 minutes

1. **Take the CETAG Quick Assessment** (Part 1) — rate your team 1-5 on each dimension. Be honest, not hopeful. (10 minutes)
2. **Identify your weakest dimension.** This is your focus area. (5 minutes)
3. **Set up the Weekly Pulse** (Part 4) — create your spreadsheet, form, or Slack workflow. Keep it simple. You can upgrade later. (20 minutes)
4. **Schedule retention conversations** for later this week — block 30 minutes with each direct report. (10 minutes)

Day 2 (Tuesday): Listen

Time required: 30 minutes per person

Start your diagnostic conversations. Use the questions from Part 2 that correspond to your weakest dimension.

In each conversation:

- Ask 3-4 diagnostic questions
- Listen more than you talk (80/20 rule)
- Take notes on patterns, not just individual responses
- Thank people for their honesty — especially if they say something uncomfortable

After all conversations, synthesize:

- What themes emerged?
- What surprised you?
- What confirms what you already suspected?

Day 3 (Wednesday): Analyze

Time required: 60 minutes

1. **Map your findings to the CETAG dimensions.** (20 minutes)

Dimension	Score	Key Finding	One Specific Issue
Clarity	___	___	___
Energy	___	___	___
Trust	___	___	___
Alignment	___	___	___

Dimension	Score	Key Finding	One Specific Issue
Growth	___	___	___

2. **Determine if you have one of the three common problems** from Part 3. (10 minutes)
   - Silent Team? → Playbook 1
   - Hamster Wheel? → Playbook 2
   - Revolving Door? → Playbook 3
3. **Identify your "one thing."** What's the single highest-leverage action you can take this week? Not three things. Not a plan. One thing. (15 minutes)
4. **Write it down and commit to a timeline.** "By Friday, I will ____." (5 minutes)

Day 4 (Thursday): Act

Time required: Variable

Execute your "one thing."

Some examples of high-leverage Day 4 actions:

If your weakest dimension is...	Your Day 4 action might be...
Clarity	Write and share a one-page team direction document (where we are, where we're going, top 3 priorities)
Energy	Cancel 2-3 low-value recurring meetings and announce why
Trust	Hold a team session where you model vulnerability — share a mistake and what you learned
Alignment	Facilitate a "priority alignment" exercise — have everyone write down top 3 priorities, compare, discuss gaps
Growth	Have a career growth conversation with the person you're most worried about losing

Don't try to solve everything. Do one thing well.

Day 5 (Friday): Measure and Plan

Time required: 30 minutes

1. **Send out your first Weekly Pulse.** (5 minutes)
2. **Reflect on the week.** (15 minutes)
   - What did you learn about your team that you didn't know on Monday?
   - How did people respond to your diagnostic conversations?
   - Did your "one thing" make a difference? How do you know?
3. **Plan next week.** (10 minutes)
   - If you identified a common problem (Silent Team, Hamster Wheel, Revolving Door), begin the 30-day playbook on Monday.
   - If not, identify the next "one thing" for next week.
   - Schedule your Monday Morning Ritual (15 minutes) to review the Pulse data.

The Complete Diagnostic Question Bank

Here are all 44 diagnostic questions organized by dimension and setting, ready to use.

Clarity Questions

For 1:1s:

1. What are the three most important things you're working on right now, and why do they matter?
2. If you had to cut your workload by half tomorrow, what would you keep?
3. When you finish a piece of work, how do you know if it was good enough?
4. What's one thing you've spent time on this month that you're not sure actually matters?
5. If a new person joined the team tomorrow, what would be the hardest thing to explain?
6. What decision have you been waiting for someone else to make?
7. Walk me through how you decided what to work on this morning.
8. What would need to be true for you to make more decisions without checking with me?

For teams: 9. Let's each write down the team's top three priorities. No talking. *(Compare.)* 10. For our current top initiative — who is the single person responsible for its success?

Energy Questions

For 1:1s: 11. On a scale of 1-10, how would you rate your energy at work? What would move it up one point? 12. What drains your energy the most at work? 13. When was the last time you were genuinely excited about a piece of work? 14. If I could remove one thing from your plate, what would make the biggest difference? 15. How much of your week is direct value creation vs. work about work? 16. When you leave on Friday, do you feel accomplished or just relieved? 17. Are there recurring frustrations you've stopped bringing up?

For teams: 18. Let's list every recurring meeting. What would happen if we stopped each one? 19. What's one process nobody would miss if it disappeared?

Trust Questions

For 1:1s: 20. When was the last time you disagreed with someone on the team openly? How did it go? 21. Is there anything about how the team works that you haven't brought up? 22. If you made a significant mistake this week, what would happen? 23. Who on the team do you go to when you're stuck? Who do you avoid? 24. What's one thing I've done recently that wasn't helpful? 25. Do you feel like your input is genuinely considered in decisions? 26. Do you share bad news early, or wait until you have a solution?

For teams: 27. What are we as a team pretending isn't a problem? 28. On a scale of 1-5, how honest are our retrospectives?

Alignment Questions

For 1:1s: 29. What's the team's biggest bet right now? Is it the right one? 30. What project or initiative should we stop doing? 31. When another team makes a decision that affects us, do you understand why? 32. How would you describe what our team is trying to achieve this quarter? 33. What trade-off have we made recently that you disagree with?

For teams: 34. Let's map what each person thinks is top priority vs. what they're spending time on. 35. Where are our dependencies on other teams? Are they working smoothly?

Growth Questions

For 1:1s: 36. What's one skill you've developed in the last six months? 37. Where do you see yourself in two years? Is this role getting you there? 38. What's the last thing you failed at? What did you learn? 39. Is

there someone whose job you'd like to learn more about? 40. If you could redesign your role, what would you change? 41. Are you growing faster, slower, or the same as six months ago? 42. What could I do to better support your development?

For teams: 43. If we could invest in one team-wide capability, what should it be? 44. Who has grown the most recently? What enabled it?

Quick Reference: The CETAG Cheat Sheet

Print this. Keep it on your desk. Refer to it before every 1:1.

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┌──────────────────────────────────────────────┐
│              CETAG TEAM HEALTH MODEL         │
├──────────┬───────────────────────────────────┤
│ CLARITY  │ Does everyone know what to do and why?  │
│          │ → Priorities, roles, success metrics    │
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│ ENERGY   │ Does the team have fuel to do great work?│
│          │ → Meaning + progress – friction         │
├──────────┼───────────────────────────────────┤
│ TRUST    │ Can people be honest and take risks?    │
│          │ → Safety, feedback, accountability      │
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│ ALIGNMENT│ Is everyone pulling the same direction? │
│          │ → Strategy, trade-offs, commitment      │
├──────────┼───────────────────────────────────┤
│ GROWTH   │ Are people developing and advancing?    │
│          │ → Skills, challenges, career paths      │
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Weekly Pulse Questions:
1. I knew what to focus on (Clarity)
2. I had energy for my best work (Energy)
3. I felt comfortable being honest (Trust)
4. My work connected to something that matters (Alignment)
5. I learned or grew this week (Growth)

The Fix Priority:
Red flag? → Diagnose with CETAG → Find weakest dimension
→ Deploy relevant playbook → Track with Weekly Pulse
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Final Words

I started this playbook by saying that the best time to fix a team problem was three months ago. The second best time is today.

You now have everything you need:

- A framework for understanding team health (CETAG)
- 44 diagnostic questions to surface the truth
- Three detailed playbooks for the most common problems
- A lightweight weekly system to track progress
- Real stories showing what these dynamics look like in practice
- A five-day action plan to get started

Here's what I've learned after twenty years of building teams: there is no perfect team. There is no state where everything works and you can stop paying attention. Team health is a practice, not a destination.

The leaders who build great teams aren't the ones with the best strategies or the biggest budgets. They're the ones who pay attention to the humans in front of them. Who ask the hard questions. Who act on what they hear. Who do the uncomfortable work of creating conditions where talented people can do their best work.

That's the job. It's not glamorous. It doesn't show up in OKRs or board decks. But it's the foundation everything else is built on.

Now go. Talk to your team. Ask the questions. Listen to the answers. And do one thing about it — starting tomorrow morning.

— Janis Rozenblats

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Appendix: Recommended Reading

These are books that shaped my thinking about teams and leadership. They're not required reading — this playbook stands on its own — but if you want to go deeper:

- **Radical Candor** by Kim Scott — The best framework for giving and receiving honest feedback
- **Thick Face, Black Heart** by Chin-Ning Chu — Unconventional wisdom about inner strength and resilience in leadership
- **Lead from the Future** by Mark W. Johnson and Josh Suskewicz — How to think about where you're going, not just where you are
- **The Five Dysfunctions of a Team** by Patrick Lencioni — A foundational model for team dysfunction (my CETAG framework builds on and extends this)
- **Managing Corporate Lifecycles** by Ichak Adizes — The CAPI framework and organizational lifecycle thinking that deeply influenced my approach
- **Turn the Ship Around!** by L. David Marquet — Intent-based leadership and distributing decision-making authority

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Thank you for investing in this playbook. If it helps you build a healthier team, I'd love to hear about it: janis@operatingleader.com